

When **BRAND** Becomes **AN ASSET**



In the business world, character always outshines credentials. From philosophy to identity and associations, there is a process to build a standout brand. In his ongoing series on business asset management, next the author takes on how your brand can become your greatest asset. Your brand's character holds the key



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All products have a story; any product without a story is a commodity! Let that sink in first.

You know it is reasonable to say we live in a time of abundant choices. It is rare to come across a product or service that is completely unique. In fact, think about a few other people or businesses who have similar offerings as you do. Whether that is hardware, software, subscription-based services, platforms of any kind, or anything else. For each of these types of options, there are more than three to four vendors in the market.

So, when the offerings are similar, where is the difference? Where is that competitive advantage? And if there is none, your product or service soon becomes a commodity that must compete

in price. Commanding a premium becomes out of the question.

Now, we all understand that it is easier to catch up with any physical product distinction. The only elusive distinction, that is hard to nail down, is perception. How your customers perceive your offering, how much they feel connected to it and why. That's what transforms your product into a 'brand.'

For any brand to become a brand in the first place, being known, liked, and trusted is a basic requirement. Being known is relatively easy. Basic marketing or an ad budget can (almost) get you there. But the key is going to be—what are you known for? Why would people see you differently and place you on a separate chair in their mind space? Why